

Serena DeStefani

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Academic Positions

- Postdoctoral Fellow, The Ohio State University, Psychiatry Department, August 2023 – present.

Education

- Ph.D. Cognitive Psychology, Rutgers University, October 2023.
- Cognitive Science Certificate, Rutgers University Center for Cognitive Science (RUCCS), October 2022.
- M.S. Cognitive Psychology, Rutgers University, May 2019.
- B.A. Psychology and Statistics, Columbia University, *magna cum laude*, May 2015.

Funding & Awards

- OSU Postdoctoral Service Award (2025).
- OSU summer fund (2025).
- OK-PROS – Kellogg Foundation Postdoctoral Recruitment and Onboarding Supplement (2024).
- NSF EAGER Grant 21221119, “Cognitive Models of Human Social Wayfinding for the Redesign of Public Spaces” (2022 – 2023).
- COVID relief fund – HEERF III (2021 – 2022).
- BITSS Research Transparency and Reproducibility Training Financial Support (2018).
- Columbia University School of General Studies William W. Strong Scholarship (2013 – 2015).

Refereed Publications

- Kemp, K., Blain, S. D., Zehra, S., **DeStefani, S.**, Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C. A., Costanza, C., Burton, C. Z., Moe, A., & Tso, I. F. (2026). Sex differences in social cognition: Insights from a sample enriched for social dysfunction. *PLoS ONE*.
- Mathis, K., Blain, S. D., Locarno, L., Lasagna, C., **DeStefani, S.**, Kraft, J., Colombi, C., Thakkar, K., Burton, C., & Tso, I. F. (2026). The link between basic visual processing and higher-level social cognition: Eye gaze perception as a bridge in a transdiagnostic sample enriched with social dysfunction. *Journal of Psychological Medicine*.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Blain, S., Kraft, J., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Turner, J.,

Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2026) The dynamics of social gaze: visual attention and autonomic arousal among individuals with varying levels of autistic traits. *Research in Autism*.

- Sohn, S., **DeStefani, S.**, Schwartz, M., Roberts, F., Stromswold, K., Kapadia, M., Feldman, J. (2025). On the Separability of Human Navigational Behaviors in Virtual Reality. *Proceedings for the 47th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, Cognitive Science Society*.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Stromswold, K., & Feldman, J. (2020). Integration of visual and spoken cues in a virtual reality navigation task. In S. Denison, M. Mack, Y. Xu & B. C. Armstrong (Eds.), *Proceedings for the 42nd Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, Cognitive Science Society*.
- Sohn, S., **DeStefani, S.**, Kapadia, M. (2018). Dynamic Cognitive Maps for Agent Landmark Navigation in Unseen Environments. *MIG 2018 Proceedings, Limassol, Cyprus*.

Under Review (* student co-author)

- *Kvetnoy, A., Suchojad, J., **DeStefani, S.**, Stromswold, K., Feldman, J. (2025) The role of eye gaze in social wayfinding. (in revision)
- **DeStefani, S.**, Sohn, S., Schwartz, M., *Sharma, Y., Roberts, F., Stromswold, K., Kapadia, M., Feldman, J. (2025), Behavioral effects of anti-pandemic preventive measures: a VR study.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Blain, S., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Turner, J., Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2026) Visual Exploration Efficiency Moderates the Association Between Autistic Traits and Social Cognition.

Conference Talks

- **DeStefani, S.**, Blain, S., Kraft, J., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Turner, J., Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2026) Visual Exploration Efficiency Moderates the Association between Autistic Traits and Social Cognition, Conference talk at the Society for Research in Psychopathology annual conference, Columbus, OH.
- **DeStefani S.** Blain, S., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Turner, J., Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2026) Distinct eye movement pathways mediate the effect of psychotic traits on social cognition, Conference Talk at the Consortium for Vision and Oculomics in Psychiatry, Third Annual Conference, Rochester, NY.
- Morales, J., Tso, I., Mathis, K., **DeStefani, S.**, Moe, A., & Breitborde, N. (2026) Disrupted Early Visual and Later Attention Processing in Person with Schizophrenia to Faces during an Emotional Go/NoGo Task. Conference talk at the Schizophrenia International Research Society (SIRS), Florence, Italy.
- **DeStefani S.** Blain, S., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Turner, J., Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2025) Altered eye movements as the missing link between basic vision impairments and social-cognitive dysfunction in psychosis, Conference Talk at the Consortium for Vision and Oculomics in Psychiatry, Second Annual Conference, Rochester, NY.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Akhter, S., Kowler, E., Stromswold, K. and Feldman, J. (2018). The Effect of Multimodal Information on Virtual Navigation. Talk, AttLis Workshop, Trondheim, Norway.

Presentations at Conferences and Meetings (* student co-author)

- **DeStefani, S.**, Blain, S., Kraft, J., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Turner, J., Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2025) The dynamics of social gaze, Conference poster presented at the Society for Research in Psychopathology annual conference, Los Angeles, CA.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Blain, S., Kraft, J., Locarno, L., Mathis, K., Lasagna, C., Colombi, C., Burton, C., Thakkar, K., Tso, I. (2024) The dynamics of social gaze: how task demands influence visual attention, Presentation, STEAM Exchange, The Ohio State University.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Sohn, S., Schwartz, M., Sharma, Y., Roberts, F., Stromswold, K., Kapadia, M., Feldman, J. (2023), How Social Affordances Shape Spatial Cognition. Poster presented at the Rutgers Robotics Workshop, New Brunswick, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Sohn, S., *Kabir, A., Feldman, J., (2022) How Optimal is too Optimal? Expectations About Performance in the Traveling Salesman Problem, Conference poster presented at CogSci Conference. Toronto.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Feldman, J., How Negative Schizotypy Influences Decision-Making in the Beads Task. (2022) Poster presented at the CPC++ conference, New York, NY.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Stromswold, K. & Feldman, J. (2022). Social Factors Influence Indoor Virtual Navigation. Conference poster, VSS, Tampa, FL.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Sohn, S., *Kabir, A., Kapadia, M. & Feldman, J. (2021) Local and Global Strategies in Navigational Decisions. Poster presented at the Rutgers Robotics Workshop, Piscataway, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Sohn, S., *Kabir, A., Kapadia, M. & Feldman, J. (2021) The Interplay Between Local and Global Strategies in Navigational Decisions. Conference poster at CogSci Conference, online.
- **DeStefani, S.** (2021). How Negative Schizotypy Influences Decision-Making in the Beads Task, Talk, Rutgers-Princeton Center for Computational Cognitive Neuro-Psychiatry (CCNP).
- **DeStefani, S.**, Schaumann, D., Zhang, X., Feldman, J., & Kapadia, M. (2020). Spatial and Non-Spatial Factors in Wayfinding. *Journal of Vision*, 20(11), 1664–1664, Conference Poster.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Schaumann, D., S., Zhang, X., Feldman, J. & Kapadia, M. (2020). The Space Within. 3MT competition, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.** (2019). How Negative Schizotypy Influences Decision Making. Talk, Cognitive Science Graduate Talk Series, Rutgers University, Piscataway, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Kowler, E., Stromswold, K., *Akhter, S., and Feldman, J. (2019). A Model of Prior Beliefs about the Trustworthiness of Navigational Cues Explains Bias Toward Auditory Stimuli. Conference Poster, APS, Washington DC.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Schaumann, D., S., Zhang, X., Feldman, J. & Kapadia, M. (2019). The Influence of Space Semantics on Navigational Choices in Virtual Settings. Conference poster, VSS, Tampa, FL.
- *Kabir, A., **DeStefani, S.**, S., Sohn, Feldman, J. & Kapadia, M. (2019) Perception of Intelligence in Decision-Making, Aresty Research Program, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.**, Sohn, S., Kapadia, M., Feldman, J. & Pantelis, P. (2018). Efficiency in Solving the Traveling Salesman Problem as Predictor of Perceived Humanness. Conference poster at CogSci Conference,

Madison, WI.

- **DeStefani, S.,** Sohn, S., Kapadia, M., Feldman, J. & Pantelis, P. (2018). Perception of Intentionality in Avatars and AI Agents. Conference poster, VSS, Tampa, FL.
- **DeStefani, S.** (2018). Computational Models of False Beliefs. Talk, Cognitive Science Graduate Talk Series, Rutgers University, Piscataway, NJ.
- Sohn, S., **DeStefani, S.,** Kapadia, M. (2018). Investigating the Role of Memory and Communication in Navigating Unseen Environments Using Cognitive Maps. Extended Abstract, AAMAS 2018 Proceedings, Stockholm, Sweden.
- **DeStefani, S.,** Sohn, S., Kapadia, M., Feldman, J. & Pantelis, P. (2018). Comparing Solutions to the Traveling Salesman Task in a Turing Test Situation. Poster presented at the Rutgers Postgraduate Symposium, Piscataway, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.,** Cornwell, J.F.M., Higgins, E.T. (2017). Prosocial Behavior and Attitude Change. Conference Poster, APS, Boston, MA.
- **DeStefani, S.,** Kowler, E., Stromswold, K., *Akhter, S., and Feldman, J. (2017). Multisensory Integration in a Virtual Reality Maze. Conference Abstract, Journal of Vision, 2017, Vol.17, p1351, VSS, Tampa, FL.
- **DeStefani, S.,** *Akhter, S., Kowler, E., Stromswold, K. and Feldman, J. (2016). Decision Making in a Virtual Reality Maze. Poster presented at the Perceptual Science Forum, Rutgers University, Piscataway, NJ.
- **DeStefani, S.,** Cornwell, J.F.M., Higgins, E.T. (2014). The Role of Self-Perceived Success in Altruistic Behavior. Conference poster at the Stanford University Undergraduate Psychology Conference, Stanford, CA.

Teaching Experience

Rutgers University, New Brunswick, NJ

- Expository Writing, Instructor (2020F).
- Quantitative Methods in Psychology, Instructor (2017Summer, 2018Summer, 2020Summer).
- Research Design & Analysis, Teaching Assistant and Lecturer (2017F).
- Cognition Lab, Instructor (2016F, 2017S, 2017F, 2018S, 2018F, 2019S, 2019F, 2020S).
- Sensation and Perception, Teaching Assistant (2016S).
- Cognition, Teaching Assistant (2015F, 2016S).

Columbia University, New York, NY

- Introduction to Psychology, Teaching Assistant and guest lecturer (2013S, 2014F, 2014S).
- Peer Advisor, Psychology department (2013F, 2014S, 2014F, 2015S).
- Columbia University American Success Program (ASP), Teaching Assistant (2013Summer).
- ISERP Summer Undergraduate Research Program, Research Assistant (2013Summer).

Pedagogy Training

- Introduction to College Teaching Course (Spring 2021).
- Online and Hybrid Teaching Course (Spring 2021).
- Supporting an Inclusive Classroom Workshop (Spring 2019).

Student Supervision

- Fall 2022: Alexis Kvetnoy, Xiaohui Meng.
- Summer 2022: Rachel Kaniuk, Richard Ruiz.
- Spring 2022: Jill Patel, Cynthia Lando, Prajna Kurkal, Brian Kong.
- Spring 2020: Li-Jie Lin.
- Fall 2020 – Spring 2021: Adeeb Kabir.

Service

- The Ohio State University Postdoctoral Association Co-Chair (Spring 2025 – present) and Co-Chair for the Professional Development Committee (Fall 2024 – Spring 2025).
- Columbia University GS Alumni Association, Board Member (since 2017) and Award Committee Co-Chair (2022 – present).
- Rutgers Psychology Department Diversity Committee, graduate advisor (Fall 2020 – Spring 2022).
- Rutgers Cognitive Science Graduate Student Organization, Treasurer (Fall 2017 – Spring 2019), President (Fall 2019 – Spring 2023).
- Rutgers Graduate Workshop on Language and Cognitive Science, organizer (2018).

Ad Hoc Reviewer

- *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*
- *Biological Psychiatry*
- *PLOS ONE*
- *Cognition*
- *Cognitive Science*
- Cognitive Science Society

Technical Skills

Languages: English (fluent), Italian (native)
Programming: R, Matlab, Python
Study Design: PsychoPy (advanced), Qualtrics (advanced)

References

- Jacob Feldman, jacob@rucss.rutgers.edu
- Steven Silverstein, Steven_Silverstein@urmc.rochester.edu
- Anna Konova, anna.konova@rutgers.edu